

BASIC

BASIC (Beginner's All-purpose Symbolic Instruction Code) was developed at Dartmouth College in the USA in 1964. Maths professors John G Kemeny (1926–1992) and Thomas E Kurtz (b. 1928) wanted a simple language that they could use to teach programming. They also developed a system where programmers could run their code immediately after entering it at a terminal. Before this, students' programs would be queued and run hours later.

"Everybody... should learn how to program a computer, because it teaches you how to think."

Steve Jobs (1955–2011), American co-founder of Apple

▷ BASIC for all

BASIC was designed to be easy to learn for everyone, not just mathematicians. As a result, writing course-related BASIC programs became part of the syllabus for many students at Dartmouth University, regardless if they were studying to be engineers, doctors, or to work in the arts.



Home computers

BASIC's popularity really took off in the 1970s and 1980s, when home computers first became available. Most machines came with a version of BASIC, which became many people's introduction to programming. The syntax of the language was straightforward and easy to learn, and allowed people to write software to help them in their businesses, or as a hobby. It gave people the power to "hack their own machine", enabling them to write the software they wanted rather than being restricted to what already existed.

READY

```
10 PRINT "HELLO, WORLD!"
20 GOTO 10
RUN ■
```

This program will keep printing "HELLO, WORLD!" until it is stopped.

◁ BBC BASIC

In 1981, BBC Micro was launched. It contained a version of BASIC that was used by schoolchildren all across the UK to learn how to code.

REAL WORLD

Raspberry Pi

Since the 1990s, computers have become increasingly user friendly, to the point that this has discouraged people from experimenting with programming. English inventor Eben Upton (b. 1978) developed the Raspberry Pi in 2012, in an effort to reverse this trend. A very low-cost, simple computer, the Raspberry Pi comes with Python and Scratch as standard, and can be used for all kinds of projects.

